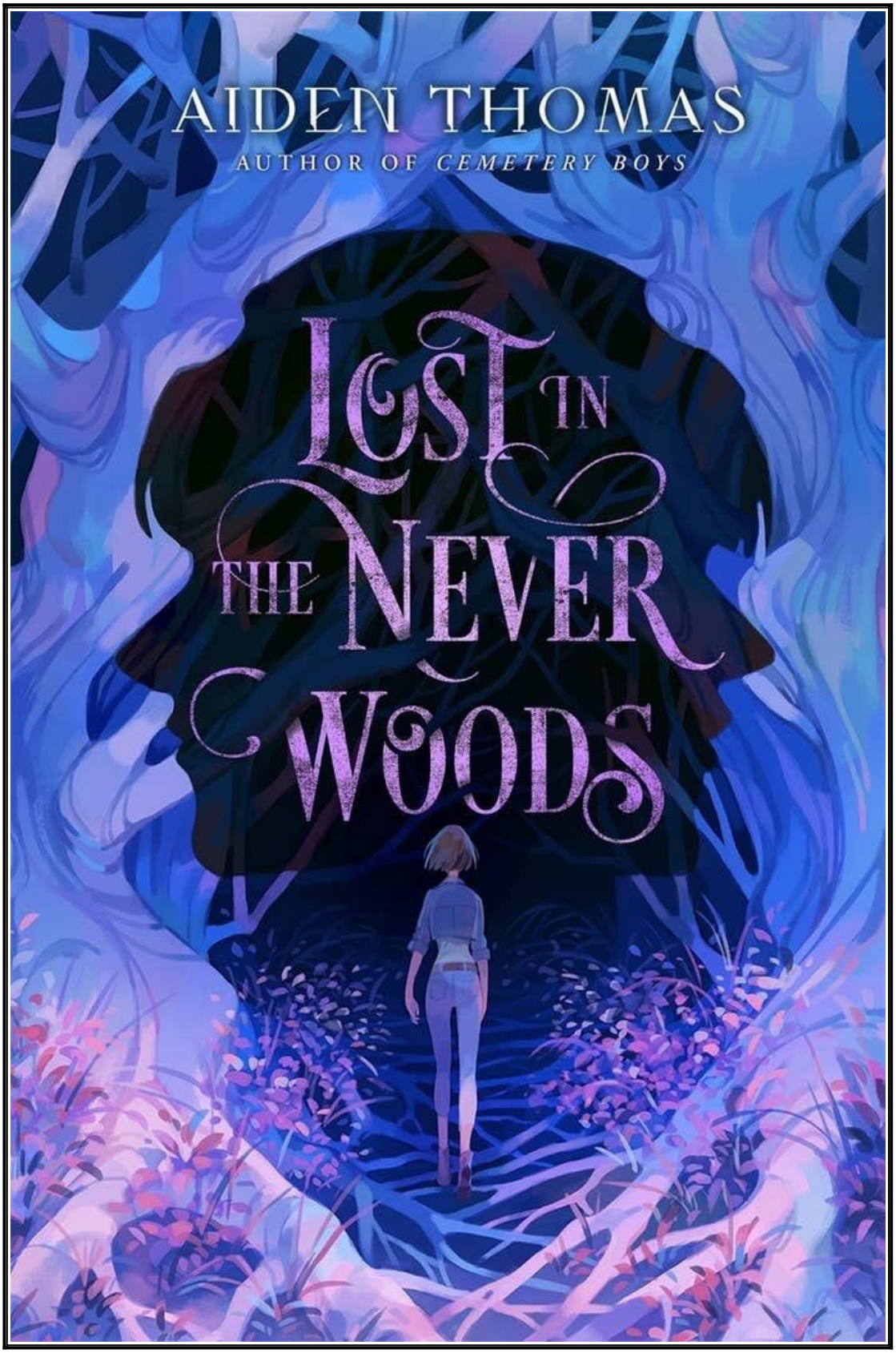


Lost in the Never Woods

Author: Aiden Thomas

Genre: YA Mystery / Magical Realism / Dark Fantasy

Description: Five years ago, Wendy Darling and her brothers went missing in the woods. Only Wendy returned, with no memory of what happened. Now, children are disappearing again, and a mysterious boy named Peter—who looks exactly like the "fictional" character from her stories—has appeared in her yard, claiming he needs her help to stop the shadows.

Introduction

In the small, mist-heavy town of Astoria, the woods aren't just a collection of trees; they are a living, breathing graveyard of memories. Wendy Darling is nearly eighteen, struggling to live a "normal" life while the town whispers about the day her brothers, John and Michael, vanished into thin air. Her parents are shells of themselves, and Wendy is haunted by gaps in her mind that feel like jagged glass. When she nearly hits a boy with her car in the middle of a storm—a boy who shouldn't exist—the past comes screaming back.

Chapter 1: The Boy in the Road

The disappearances start again. First one child, then another. The town is paralyzed by fear, but Wendy is distracted by the stranger hiding in her treehouse. He calls himself **Peter**. He is charming, frantic, and looks like he hasn't aged a day since the stories Wendy’s mother used to tell. Peter claims his "Shadow" has escaped and is the one taking the children. To save them, Wendy must do the one thing she promised never to do: go back into the trees.

Chapter 2: Tracing the Roots

Wendy and Peter begin an uneasy partnership. As they venture into the Never Woods, the forest begins to react to Wendy’s presence. The trees shift, and the colors turn from natural greens to surreal purples and blues. Wendy starts experiencing "echoes"—visions of her brothers playing in these very woods. She realizes that her memories weren't lost; they were stolen. Peter admits that Neverland wasn't a magical paradise, but a place where time stands still at a terrible price.

Chapter 3: The Shadow’s Hunger

The mystery deepens when Wendy finds her brother John’s old glasses near a hollowed-out oak. The Shadow isn't just a silhouette; it’s a sentient, dark reflection of Peter’s own grief and forgotten past. It feeds on the memories of children, leaving them as "Lost Boys"—hollow versions of themselves. Wendy discovers that she survived five years ago because she made a deal, but she can't remember the terms.

Chapter 4: The Heart of the Woods

They reach the center of the Never Woods, where the veil between the real world and the "Never" is thinnest. Wendy finally confronts the Shadow, which takes the form of her missing brothers to taunt her. She realizes the truth: she didn't just forget her brothers; she left them behind to save herself. To defeat the Shadow, she must stop running from the guilt of surviving and reclaim the memories she buried.

Chapter 5: Finding the Way Home

In a climactic confrontation, Wendy uses her old stories as a map to anchor herself to reality. She helps Peter bind the Shadow, but at a cost. The children are returned to the edge of town, but the "Never" is receding, and Peter must go with it. Wendy says a final, heartbreaking goodbye to the boy from her stories and the ghosts of her brothers. She walks out of the woods for the last time, no longer a girl lost in a fairy tale, but a woman ready to live in the real world.

Some stories are meant to stay in the woods; others are meant to be told so we can finally move on.